

A FAITHFUL PATH COMMUNITY GUIDE

The Christian Spiritual Reset

*A 3-Day Guided Retreat to Overcome Burnout,
Hear God Clearly, and Renew Your Faith*

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FAITHFUL PATH COMMUNITY

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CHAPTER 7

Setting Your Intention

You have a length and a place, or at least a target for both. Before we prepare your heart more deliberately, and before we address your phone and packing, there is one short exercise that will shape everything else: deciding, honestly, why you are going.

This sounds obvious. It is not. People often arrive at a retreat with no clear intention, an exhausting list of things to fix, or a spiritual-sounding purpose that conceals what they truly want. None of these serves you well.

A retreat intention is a brief, honest description of what you are bringing before God. It is provisional, not controlling: it gives you a place to begin while leaving God free to redirect your attention. It is not a goal list, and it is not a performance. It is one honest sentence to God about what you are bringing and what you are asking.

"What do you want me to do for you?"

In **Mark 10:46–52**, a blind beggar named Bartimaeus hears that Jesus is passing through Jericho and starts shouting. The crowd tells him to be quiet. He shouts louder. Jesus stops, calls him over, and asks a question that at first seems unnecessary: "What do you want me to do for you?" The man is blind. Everyone can see what

he needs. But Jesus asks anyway, and Bartimaeus has to say it out loud: "Rabbi, I want to see."

Jesus asked the same question of James and John a few verses earlier (Mark 10:36), and their answer, seats of honour in his kingdom, revealed something about them that they might not have admitted otherwise. Jesus did not need Bartimaeus to make his condition visible, but the question required the man to name his desire. The same question asked of James and John exposed a very different desire. In both cases, the answer revealed the heart of the person asking. Saying what we want, plainly, in his hearing, tells us the truth about ourselves. It moves us from a vague hope that something will happen to an honest request whose outcome we entrust to God. His response may affirm, redirect, delay, or reshape what we have asked.

Your intention for this retreat is your answer to that question. Not the answer you think a mature Christian should give. The real one.

Intention is not a list

The first mistake is to arrive with too much. I have seen retreat plans that read like a project charter: resolve my calling, forgive my father, decide about the job, restart my prayer life, plan the next year, and lose the anxiety. Each of those may be real, but together they turn the retreat into work, and you already have enough of that.

Psalms 27:4 offers a different posture. David knew danger, opposition, responsibility, and many competing needs. Yet he writes: "One thing have I asked of the LORD, that will I seek after: that I may dwell in the house of the LORD all the days of my life, to gaze upon the beauty of the LORD and to inquire in his temple." One thing. Not because he had only one need, but

because he gathered his desire into the one that lay underneath the others.

The purpose is not to discover the one perfect sentence that explains your entire life. It is to identify the concern or desire that seems most important to bring before God at this time. Other concerns may surface during the retreat, and your intention is allowed to change. A good intention usually sounds less like "I want to resolve X, Y, and Z" and more like "I have been carrying this alone for a long time and I need to set it down in front of you," or "I have lost the sense that you are near, and I want to be honest with you about that," or "I am facing a decision and I am afraid of getting it wrong, and I want to listen before I choose."

Here is the difference between an expectation and an intention, side by side:

Outcome-focused expectation	Open-handed intention
"God must tell me whether to leave my job."	"I want to bring my fear and uncertainty about work before God without forcing an immediate answer."
"I must forgive everything by Sunday."	"I want to become honest about the wound and open to the next safe step toward freedom."
"I need to feel God again."	"I want to remain present with God and truthful about the distance I feel."
"This retreat must cure my burnout."	"I want to recognise what has emptied me and become willing to change what I can."

Intention is not a performance

The second mistake is the opposite of the first. Some readers will write an intention that is entirely correct and entirely hollow: "I want to draw closer to God and be renewed in my faith." There is nothing wrong with the sentence. But if the truer sentence is "I am so angry about what happened that I cannot pray, and I have not told anyone," then the polished version is a way of avoiding the retreat before it starts.

Scripture does not reward polished prayers. Hannah, in **1 Samuel 1:9–18**, was so distressed that she prayed without sound, only her lips moving, and the priest Eli assumed she was drunk. She brought her anguish and longing before God without disguising either. She asked for a child and later described herself as a woman "pouring out my soul before the LORD." That is the honesty an intention should have. God already knows the unpolished version. Writing it down is for you, so that you enter the retreat as the person you actually are.

To test your intention, read the sentence slowly and ask:

- Is this what I truly want to bring to God?
- Am I using general spiritual language to avoid something more specific?
- Does this sentence sound like me?
- Can I say it without pretending to feel something I do not feel? An honest intention may be deeply private, but it does not have to be embarrassing to be real. Sometimes the most important intention is the one we have been reluctant to acknowledge. But you do not need to force yourself to disclose more than you can safely hold.

The intention you are hiding

Underneath the stated intention there is sometimes a hidden one, and it is worth naming, because hidden intentions shape the retreat whether you acknowledge them or not.

Some people go on retreat hoping God will confirm a decision they have already made. Some go hoping he will change a person who is not there. Some go to prove to themselves, or to someone else, that they are still spiritual. Some go to escape a conversation they are supposed to be having. Some go because they are hoping for a dramatic experience that will make everything feel real again.

None of these disqualifies you. But each of them, left unspoken, can distort what you hear. If you are seeking only confirmation, you may interpret every impression as confirmation. If you are primarily seeking escape, you may mistake temporary relief for lasting direction. So ask yourself, and write it down: *What am I hoping for that I have not said?* Then bring that to God as well.

Your motives do not have to be perfectly pure before you begin. Few human motives are. The purpose is not to eliminate every mixed desire, but to bring as much of yourself into the light as you presently can. **Psalm 139:23–24** is the prayer for this: "Search me, O God, and know my heart! Try me and know my thoughts! And see if there be any grievous way in me, and lead me in the way everlasting." It is a prayer to be shown what we cannot see about ourselves, and it is a good one to pray before writing anything.

Open hands

There is one more quality that a good intention needs, and Chapter 5 already introduced it. It must be held with open hands.

An intention is a request, not a demand. You bring it to God and you leave the outcome with him. You may ask for clarity about a decision and receive, instead, peace about not knowing yet. You may ask for God's felt presence and receive three days of quiet faithfulness without it. You may ask to forgive someone and discover that what you needed first was to grieve. **Jeremiah 29:13** formed part of God's promise to his exiled people that their displacement and judgment would not be the end of their story: "You will seek me and find me, when you seek me with all your heart." It does not guarantee a dramatic retreat experience, but it reveals God's desire for a people who turn toward him wholeheartedly.

We do not equate our decisions with what Jesus faced at the cross. Yet his prayer in Gethsemane gives us a profound pattern: "Remove this cup from me. Yet not what I will, but what you will" (Mark 14:36). Honest desire held together with surrender to the Father. Your intention can do both. State it plainly, and then add, in whatever words are yours, *but I am open to what you have for me instead.*

Open hands do not mean passivity toward abuse, injustice, danger, or responsibilities that require action. Surrender means refusing to manipulate the retreat into producing your preferred answer; it does not mean surrendering wisdom, boundaries, or safety.

Writing it

Here is the exercise. Take a page in your journal, or a single sheet you will bring with you, and write four things.

1. **What I am carrying.** In a few sentences, the situation you are coming from. Use what you wrote in Chapter 4's check-in.

2. **What I am asking.** One sentence, in the first person, addressed to God. The concern that matters most right now. Plain words. Hannah's honesty, not polished religious language.
3. **What I have not said.** The hidden hope or fear, if there is one.
4. **What I am releasing.** One sentence surrendering your demand for a particular retreat outcome. Name what you will refuse to force, and express your willingness to continue seeking wise help if clarity or relief does not come. For example: "God, I will not force an answer during these three days. Help me receive what becomes clear and continue patiently with what remains unresolved." If you have sufficient privacy and it feels helpful, read it aloud once as a prayer. Otherwise, read it slowly and silently before God.

You will carry this page into Session One, where it becomes the first thing you say to God on the retreat. You will read it again in the final session, where you will see what has shifted. If you have a trustworthy support person, you may choose to share your intention with them. This can provide accountability and give them a helpful question to ask afterwards. You are not required to share details that are private, unsafe to disclose, or better discussed with a qualified professional.

If you cannot find an intention

Some readers will sit with this exercise and find nothing. Not because they are hiding something, but because they are too tired or too numb to know what they want. If that is you, your intention can simply be that: "I do not know what I need. I only know I need to stop and be with you." That is a complete and honest intention, and God has met people with far less.

Elijah entered the wilderness able to name little more than his exhaustion: "It is enough." God responded first with care for his body and presence in his despair. If your words mean only, "I have reached my limit and need to stop," write that honestly, and go. But if "It is enough" means you do not want to remain alive, follow the safety guidance in Chapter 5 and seek immediate support rather than beginning the retreat alone.